3.3 Cultures of the Middle Colonies

You probably know this from your own experience with your classmates: Things just go better if you try to get along. For the most part, that's what people in the Middle Colonies discovered, too.

MAIN IDEA While the Middle Colonies made an honest attempt to tolerate different religions, tensions still existed between different races.

RELIGIOUS TOLERANCE

With people from all walks of life pouring into the Middle Colonies, neighbors needed to show religious **tolerance**, or acceptance of others, in order to establish community. This open-mindedness was part of the legacy of the Dutch. In the Netherlands, Jews practiced their religion freely and became citizens. The Dutch also welcomed many Protestant groups not recognized by the church, including Puritans, Quakers, and Lutherans. In fact, the Pilgrims who settled at Plymouth, Massachusetts, had originally gone to live in the city of Leiden in the Netherlands because of the religious tolerance they found there. The Dutch carried their practice of tolerance across the sea to New Netherland, where it continued after the English took over.

Less than 100 miles away, William Penn founded Pennsylvania as a free colony—not just for Quakers, but for other religions as well. He promised equal rights and opportunities. As a result, the colony attracted many different Protestant faiths, including the Amish. This group emphasized personal faith and a simple life. They also valued humility and submission.

Quakers believed all people were equal in the eyes of God. They saw religion as a personal matter, and they did not demand **conformity**, or obedience, to a strict set of beliefs. Quakers were also the first group in America to ban slaveholding.

TENSIONS BETWEEN RACES

But most people in the Middle Colonies didn't share the Quakers' view. When the English acquired New Netherland in 1664, an estimated 20 percent of the population was African. The Dutch West India Company provided "half freedom" to older enslaved Africans. This meant that the company released the older slaves, but not their children, from slavery. Other slaves worked for wages to buy their freedom. As a result, by 1664, one-fifth of all Africans were free. But tolerance for diversity did not extend to these Africans and African Americans, whether they were free or slaves.

Most African Americans in the Middle Colonies lived in New York City. By 1711, about 40 percent of white households there had at least one slave. Many enslaved people were skilled workers and lived and worked next to free and indentured whites.

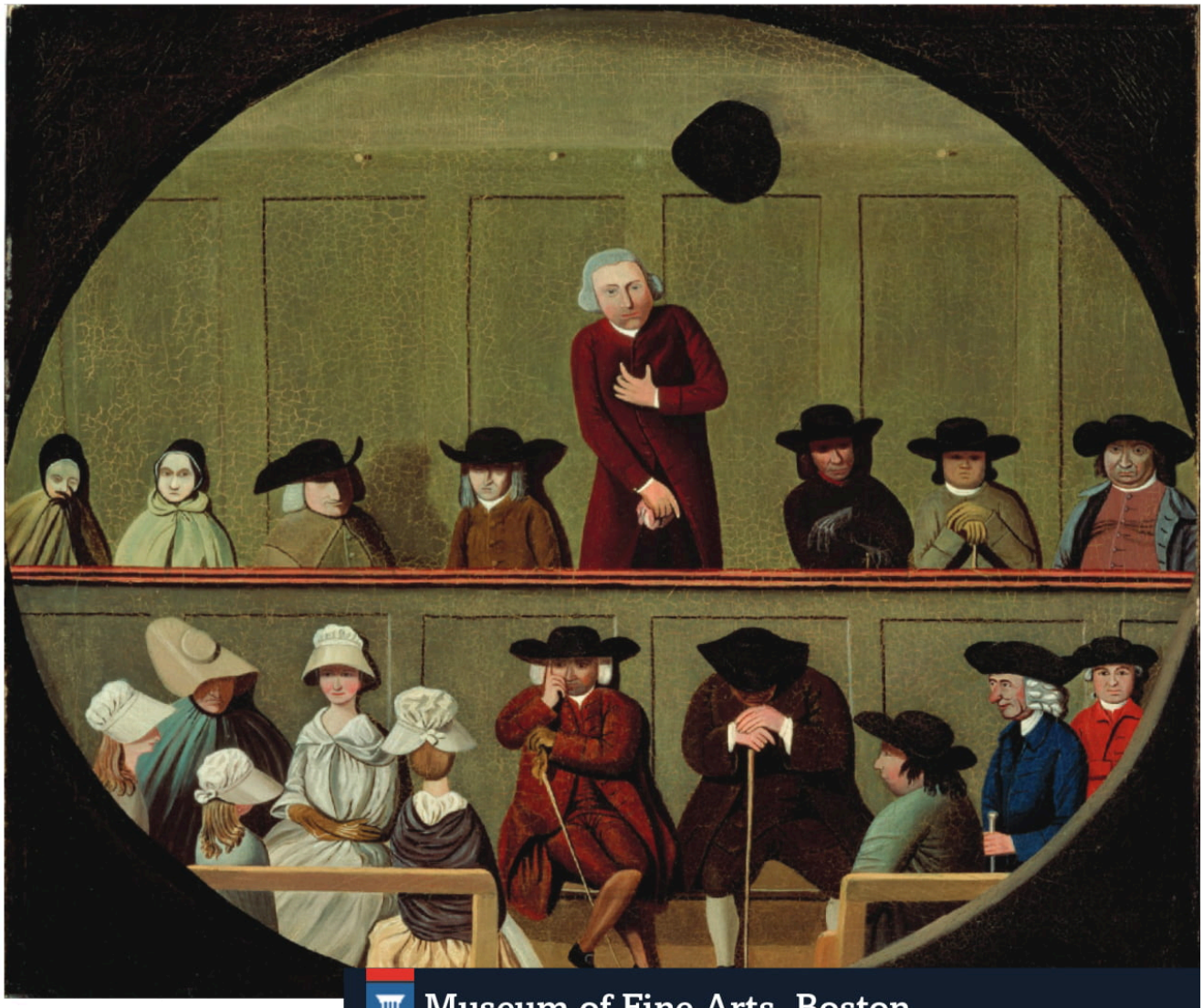
Enslaved African Americans whose owners had run out of tasks for them often sought work on their own, looking for paid work throughout New York. However, the sight of so many African Americans on the streets of New York made white people fearful. A law was put into effect requiring that all hiring of slaves be done at one place, the slave market. This put still more restrictions on the lives of the African Americans, and in turn, white people began to worry about a slave rebellion.

These fears became reality on the night of April 6, 1712, when about 20 enslaved people set fire to a building, attacking the white men who came to put it out. Nine white people were killed, and terror spread up and down the Atlantic coast.

As in the case of later slave revolts and conspiracies, the revenge taken on the African-American community far outweighed any

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Quaker Meeting, by an unidentified British artist, c. 1700–1825



Museum of Fine Arts, Boston

Like many Protestant groups, Quakers did not have a paid clergy. Instead, they believed every individual should decide how to worship. People sat silently at Quaker meetings, thinking and praying, until they felt that God moved them to speak. They wore plain clothes and spoke plainly, even to nobility. This painting by an unknown artist from the late 1700s or early 1800s captures the feeling of a Quaker meeting.

violence the rebels had committed. In the wake of the New York revolt, 13 enslaved African Americans were hanged, 3 were burned at the stake, 1 was tortured, and another starved to death in chains.

Some white colonists, however, questioned the morality of slavery. Wasn't it a violation of the Bible's golden rule, which says to act toward others as you want others to act toward you? A person who enslaves another certainly would not like to be enslaved in return. Other whites opposed slavery simply because they feared slave rebellions. Despite these considerations, slavery became a part of early American culture and would remain so for more than 150 years.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the Dutch colonists show tolerance for religious diversity in New Netherland?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why do you think Quakers accepted other religions and races?
3. **EVALUATE** The text claims that "the revenge taken on the African-American community far outweighed any violence the rebels had committed." What evidence supports this?

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